PRODUCT TEARDOWN · NEXTLEAP PM FELLOWSHIP

New User Onboarding Teardown

What Relay gets right, what it gets wrong, and what I'd fix first

March 2026

Product Overview

Context before we get into the onboarding itself

AI-native

What Relay is

A no-code automation platform with AI built in. You connect apps, define triggers, add AI steps — and it runs. No YAML, no code. SOC 2 certified, 100+ integrations as of early 2026.

Freemium PLG

How they make money

Free tier to get you in the door. Paid plans gate the number of 'steps' your automations can run each month. Pricing is on the homepage no need to talk to sales. That's intentional.

Simplicity-first

Where they sit in the market

Cheaper than Zapier at scale. Less complex than Make. More AI-native than either. The catch: Zapier has 8,000+ integrations. Relay has ~100. That gap matters for some users.

Their bet: Non-technical users will pick the tool they can actually use over the tool with the most integrations. So far, early reviews suggest they're right.

Who's actually signing up?

The target segment and two people who represent it

The core segment

Ops people, solo founders, and small team leads who need to automate things but don't have an engineer on call and can't afford to wait.

🚀 **Startup founders**
Doing everything themselves

📊 **Ops & RevOps managers**
Own the process, not the code

🛠️ **Solo builders**
One person, many hats

📣 **Marketing leads**
Need to ship automations, not learn APIs

PM

Priya, Ops Manager

Series A startup · 40 people

Goal Wire up client onboarding so new sign-ups get the right emails, Notion tasks, and Slack pings — automatically

Fear She'll spend a week building it, then nobody on her team can maintain it when she's out

Delight Had a working test run in 12 minutes. Sent the Loom to her CEO the same afternoon.

RF

Rahul, Solo Founder

Bootstrapped SaaS · 3 paying customers

Goal Replace a $200/mo tool that does one thing with a Relay workflow that does three

Fear He's tried Zapier and Make. Both broke after two weeks. He can't debug them mid-launch.

Delight Month 1 saved ₹18,000. More importantly, it didn't break.

~45M knowledge workers use no-code tools globally · Relay's sweet spot: teams of 1–50 who are past spreadsheets but not ready for engineers

What the onboarding actually looks like

Steps · emotions · friction points · and where the Aha moment is

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Discover	**Land**	**Sign Up**	**Intent Q**	**First Flow**	**★ Aha!**	**Hit a wall**	**Stay or go**
Find it comparing Zapier alternatives or via a tweet	Homepage is clear. Value prop above the fold. No fluff.	Google or Microsoft SSO. No form. Literally one click.	'What do you want to automate?' - then a blank builder. No templates shown. Key drop-off point.	Guided builder: pick trigger, add action, drop in AI.	Real data flows through live. Not dummy data — yours. This is the moment users stop evaluating and start owning.	App not in library (cited in 15/60 G2 reviews) — or step cap appears after you've already built things.	If step 7 was minor — you save it and come back tomorrow.
😐	🙂	😊	🤔	😀	🤩	😟	😌
Skeptical	Intrigued	Relieved	Unsure	Getting it	I get it now	Frustrated	Cautiously in
			⚠ friction		★ Aha moment	⚠ friction	

Based on my personal walkthrough · data points cross-referenced with 60+ verified G2 reviews and Product Hunt threads

What the design is telling us

Mapped against the PSYCH framework — six decisions, four smart, two costly

PSYCH framework: P = Pain addressed · S = Solution clarity · Y = Your user fit · C = Cost of switching · H = Habit formation

01 ✓

SSO on step one — obviously right

One click to get in. No form, no password. SSO lifts signup conversion by ~20–30% in most B2B tools. The fact that Relay leads with this, not a sign-up form, is a deliberate call.

Hick's Law · C — lowers cost of starting

02 ✓

'What do you want to automate?' — good instinct

Asking about intent before showing a blank builder is the right idea. It seeds the product with context and gives you something to work from. The problem is the follow-through (see card 5).

Progressive Disclosure · Y — matches user's job to be done

03 ✓

Live data preview — the real Aha moment

You run a test and see actual data moving through your workflow. Not dummy data. Yours. That's the moment people get it. Very few automation tools show this before you publish.

Endowment Effect · H — first habit loop formed here

04 ✓

Pricing on the homepage

You can see what you'll pay before you sign up. This filters out the wrong users and builds trust with the right ones. It's a small thing that signals a lot about how the company thinks.

PLG flywheel · P - removes 'what will this cost me?' anxiety

05 ✕

No templates after the intent question

You say 'I want to automate my sales follow-ups.' Then you get a blank builder. That gap kills activation. G2 data: 'limited features' and 'learning curve' appear in 14 out of 60+ reviews this is likely why.

Social Proof · S — solution clarity breaks down here

06 ✕

Step caps appear only after you've built things

You build a workflow. Then you notice the usage bar. Then you feel tricked. This came up in my own walkthrough and in Product Hunt threads consistently. Showing limits before activation not after is the difference between an upsell and a bad review.

Expectation Setting · P — creates new pain post-activation

Three things I'd fix and, in this order

Specific changes, not vague suggestions

1

HIGH IMPACT · LOW EFFORT

Show 5 templates right after the intent question

Problem: Right now, users say what they want to automate and then face a blank canvas. Most don't know how to start.

Fix: After the intent question, pull 5–6 matching templates and let them one-click import. The builder pre-fills with their use case. This is the single fastest win in the entire funnel.

↑ Activation · ↓ Time-to-first-workflow

2

HIGH IMPACT · MEDIUM EFFORT

Show the step counter from day 1, not when it's almost gone

Problem: Users discover there's a monthly step limit only after they've built workflows. At that point it feels like a trap.

Fix: Put a simple usage bar in the dashboard from the start. 'You've used 47 of 500 steps this month.' Frame it as room, not as a cap. Users who see the meter upgrade before hitting zero. Users who get a wall churn.

↑ Paid conversion · ↓ Churn

3

MEDIUM IMPACT · MEDIUM EFFORT

Give power users an escape hatch

Problem: Anyone coming from Make or Zapier hits the ceiling of the simplified UI within a few days.

Fix: An 'Advanced mode' toggle — opt-in, not default — that exposes node-based editing, conditional logic, and raw mapping. New users never see it. Power users stop looking for an alternative.

↑ D30 retention

What I'd actually track

The metrics that tell you if onboarding is working and where it's breaking

⭐ North star

% of sign-ups who run their first automation within 7 days of registering

Activation

Time to first workflow

Under 10 minutes is the target. More than 20 and you're losing people.

Workflow completion rate

Did they publish it, or just start it? Starting doesn't count.

Drop-off at step 4

The intent question. This is where the no-template problem shows up.

Engagement

D7 / D30 retention

Still running automations a week later? A month later?

Workflows per user per week

One workflow = testing. Three = actually using it.

Apps connected

More integrations connected = harder to churn.

Revenue

Free to paid conversion

Did they upgrade within 30 days?

Step cap hit rate

How often do users hit the monthly limit?

Time from cap-hit to paid

24 hours = working upgrade path. 7 days = you lost them.

One to watch: correlation between how clearly users answered the intent question and whether they're still active at D7.

relay.app

Thank you.

My honest take

✅ What's genuinely good

The SSO signup, the live preview, and the transparent pricing are all strong. Combined, they make this one of the less painful first-run experiences I've tried in automation tooling. That's not faint praise this category is full of bad onboarding.

⚠️ What's quietly killing retention

The blank canvas after the intent question and the hidden step cap aren't bugs, they're gaps in product thinking. Both are fixable in a sprint. The template gap especially: it's low effort, high impact, and the fix is obvious.

🎯 The underlying bet

Relay is betting that most people will trade integration breadth for ease of use. That's probably right for their current ICP. The risk: as users grow, they'll need more integrations. Whether Relay can expand fast enough to keep them is the real question.